and Asia Minor in the West, and in Iran and the Indus Valley civilisation in the east. They travelled in ships across the seas for trade. Their temples acted as banks and lent credit on their own account. The Mesopotamian documents have references to loan and repayment, with or without interest. Perhaps this is the first written evidence of charging an interest on borrowed money.

Cities and Town Planning

The Mesopotamian cities featured mud or baked brick walls with gates. Some people lived in reed huts outside the cities. The Ziggurats were at the city centre on a platform and appeared like steep pyramids, with staircases leading to the top. Around this temple were complexes of ceremonial courtyards, shrines, burial chambers for the priests and priestesses, ceremonial banquet halls, along with workshops, granaries, storehouses and administrative buildings.

Religion

The Sumerian religion was polytheistic. They worshipped several Gods and Goddesses. The Sumerians prayed to Enlil, the God of sky and wind. The city of Nippur was centre of Enlil's worship. Ninlil was the Sumerian Goddess of grain. The Babylonians worshipped Marduk, and Ashur was the supreme God of the Assyrians. Ishtar was Goddess of love and fertility, Tiamat the God of the sea and chaos, and Sin, the moon God. The kings were seen as representatives of the Gods on earth. The Mesopotamians developed a rich collection of myths and legends. The most famous of these is the epic of Gilgamesh, which is written in the cuneiform text. It contains a legend of the flood and has similarities with the account of Noah's Ark mentioned in the Bible and other myths in the Hindu *puranas*.

The Hammurabi's Law Code

The Hammurabi Code is an important legal document that specifies the laws related to various crimes. It has 282 provisions specifying cases related to family rights, trade, slavery, taxes and wages. It is carved on a stone, which portrays Hammurabi as receiving the code from the Sun God Shamash. It was a compilation of old laws based on retributive principles. 'An eye for an eye' and ' a tooth for a tooth' form of justice is used in the Hammurabi Code.



Cuneiform tablet

Cuneiform: The Sumerian Writing System

Cuneiform is the Sumerian writing system. The shape of the letter is in the form of wedge and hence it is called cuneiform. Evolving around 3000 BC (BCE), it is one of the earliest scripts of the world. They used this script for commercial transactions and writing letters and stories. The clay tablets contain loads of information on the Sumerian civilisation.

Art

The Mesopotamian art included sculptures in stone and clay. A few paintings and sculptures from the Mesopotamian times have survived today. Mesopotamian sculptures portray animals, such as goats, rams, bulls and lions. Some mythological figures like lions and bulls with human head have also been found in their art. Massive sculptures were created at the time of the Assyrian and the Babylonian empires.



A clay tablet with the accounts of sheep and goats, from Tello, southern Iraq

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